

LEARNING TO RIDE THE WAVE

From Covelong to the Asian Games, India's surfing journey is **gaining momentum**, but the Shore Temple Classic showed how much ground remains to be covered.

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For four days in August, the historic Shore Temple at Mahabalipuram overlooked a scene straight out of a movie. Nearly 100 surfers from 10 countries rode the waves as the World Surf League Shore Temple Classic QS 2000 returned to the same coast for the first time in three years. Mahabalipuram Beach also hosted the country's first-ever Pro Junior event simultaneously.

On August 15, a Saturday and the final day of the WSL, the beach drew an impressive crowd compared to the previous days of the competition. The cloudy day brought a welcome break from Mahabalipuram's usually dry and humid heat. Families gathered along the shore, while people went for runs and fishermen returned from their morning expedition. Everyone, from children to joggers and fishermen, stopped and stared as the pro surfers cut through the waves. They carved the water with incredible control and precision.

However, the excitement of the competition could not mask the disappointment of the Indian contingent. None of the Indian players, barring Kishore Kumar, made it to the quarterfinals. Kishore, a member of the 2026 Asian Games squad, reached the last eight in the Pro Junior Men's event but could not progress further. Kamali Moorthy, the other Asian Games squad member in the field, also failed to make the cut.

